

CHEATSHEET

Psychology of Design

List of cognitive biases & principles that affect your UX



	Name	One-Liner	Category
1.	👁️ <u>Hick's Law</u>	More options leads to harder decisions	Information
2.	👛 <u>Confirmation Bias</u>	People look for evidence that confirms what they think	Information
3.	👁️ <u>Priming</u>	Previous stimuli influence users' decision	Information
4.	🚚 <u>Cognitive Load</u>	Total amount of mental effort that is required to complete a task	Information
5.	⚓ <u>Anchoring Bias</u>	Users rely heavily on the first piece of information they see	Information
6.	👉 <u>Nudge</u>	Subtle hints can affect users' decisions	Information
7.	🍰 <u>Progressive Disclosure</u>	Users are less overwhelmed if they're exposed to complex features later	Information
8.	🎯 <u>Fitts's Law</u>	Large and close elements are easier to interact with	Information
9.	🐟 <u>Attentional Bias</u>	Users' thoughts filter what they pay attention to	Information
10.	❤️ <u>Empathy Gap</u>	People underestimate how much emotions influence user behaviors	Information
11.	🚢 <u>Visual Anchors</u>	Elements used to guide users' eyes	Information
12.	🌶️ <u>Von Restorff Effect</u>	People notice items that stand out more	Information
13.	🏆 <u>Visual Hierarchy</u>	The order in which people perceive what they see	Information
14.	🔭 <u>Selective Attention</u>	People filter out things from their environment when in focus	Information
15.	✈️ <u>Survivorship Bias</u>	People neglect things that don't make it past a selection process	Information
16.	🕶️ <u>Banner Blindness</u>	Users tune out the stuff they get repeatedly exposed to	Information
17.	🍒 <u>Juxtaposition</u>	Elements that are close and similar are perceived as a single unit	Information
18.	🚦 <u>Signifiers</u>	Elements that communicate what they will do	Information
19.	🎭 <u>Contrast</u>	Users' attention is drawn to higher visual weights	Information
20.	🔴 <u>External Trigger</u>	When the information on what to do next is within the prompt itself	Information
21.	👤 <u>Decoy Effect</u>	Create a new option that's easy to discard	Information

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22.	 <u>Centre-Stage Effect</u>	People tend to choose the middle option in a set of items	<u>Information</u>
23.	 <u>Framing</u>	The way information is presented affects how users make decisions	<u>Information</u>
24.	 <u>Law of Proximity</u>	Elements close to each other are usually considered related	<u>Information</u>
25.	 <u>Tesler's Law</u>	If you simplify too much, you'll transfer some complexity to the users	<u>Information</u>
26.	 <u>Spark Effect</u>	Users are more likely to take action when the effort is small	<u>Information</u>
27.	 <u>Feedback Loop</u>	When users take action, feedback communicates what happened	<u>Information</u>
28.	 <u>Expectations Bias</u>	People tend to be influenced by their own expectations	<u>Information</u>
29.	 <u>Aesthetic-Usability Effect</u>	People perceive designs with great aesthetics as easier to use	<u>Information</u>
30.	 <u>Social Proof</u>	Users adapt their behaviors based on what others do	<u>Meaning</u>
31.	 <u>Scarcity</u>	People value things more when they're in limited supply	<u>Meaning</u>
32.	 <u>Curiosity Gap</u>	Users have a desire to seek out missing information	<u>Meaning</u>
33.	 <u>Mental Model</u>	Users have a preconceived opinion of how things work	<u>Meaning</u>
34.	 <u>Familiarity Bias</u>	People prefer familiar experiences	<u>Meaning</u>
35.	 <u>Halo Effect</u>	People judge things (or people) based on their feelings towards one trait	<u>Meaning</u>
36.	 <u>Miller's Law</u>	Users can only keep 7±2 items in their working memory	<u>Meaning</u>
37.	 <u>Unit Bias</u>	One unit of something feels like the optimal amount	<u>Meaning</u>
38.	 <u>Flow State</u>	Being fully immersed and focused on a task	<u>Meaning</u>
39.	 <u>Skeuomorphism</u>	Users adapt more easily to things that look like real-world objects	<u>Meaning</u>
40.	 <u>Singularity Effect</u>	Users care disproportionately about an individual as compared to a group	<u>Meaning</u>
41.	 <u>Reciprocity</u>	People feel the need to reciprocate when they receive something	<u>Meaning</u>
42.	 <u>Authority Bias</u>	Users attribute more importance to the opinion of an authority figure	<u>Meaning</u>
43.	 <u>Pseudo-Set Framing</u>	Tasks that are part of a group are more tempting to complete	<u>Meaning</u>
44.	 <u>Variable Reward</u>	People especially enjoy unexpected rewards	<u>Meaning</u>
45.	 <u>Group Attractiveness Effect</u>	Individual items seem more attractive when presented in a group	<u>Meaning</u>
46.	 <u>Curse of Knowledge</u>	Not realizing that people don't have the same level of knowledge	<u>Meaning</u>

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47.	 <u>Aha! moment</u>	When new users first realize the value of your product	<u>Meaning</u>
48.	 <u>Self-Initiated Triggers</u>	Users are more likely to interact with prompts they setup for themselves	<u>Meaning</u>
49.	 <u>Survey Bias</u>	Users tend to skew survey answers towards what's socially acceptable	<u>Meaning</u>
50.	 <u>Cognitive Dissonance</u>	It's painful to hold two opposing ideas in our mind	<u>Meaning</u>
51.	 <u>Goal Gradient Effect</u>	Motivation increases as users get closer to their goal	<u>Meaning</u>
52.	 <u>Feedforward</u>	When users know what to expect before they take action	<u>Meaning</u>
53.	 <u>Occam's Razor</u>	Simple solutions are often better than the more complex ones	<u>Meaning</u>
54.	 <u>Noble Edge Effect</u>	Users tend to prefer socially responsible companies	<u>Meaning</u>
55.	 <u>Hawthorne Effect</u>	Users change their behavior when they know they are being observed	<u>Meaning</u>
56.	 <u>Hindsight Bias</u>	People overestimate their ability to predict outcomes after the fact	<u>Meaning</u>
57.	 <u>Law of Similarity</u>	Users perceive a relationship between elements that look similar	<u>Meaning</u>
58.	 <u>Law of Prägnanz</u>	Users interpret ambiguous images in a simpler and more complete form	<u>Meaning</u>
59.	 <u>Streisand Effect</u>	When trying to censor information ends up increasing awareness of that information	<u>Meaning</u>
60.	 <u>Spotlight Effect</u>	People tend to believe they are being noticed more than they really are	<u>Meaning</u>
61.	 <u>Fresh Start Effect</u>	Users are more likely to take action if there's a feeling of new beginnings	<u>Meaning</u>
62.	 <u>Labor Illusion</u>	People value things more when they see the work behind them	<u>Time</u>
63.	 <u>Default Bias</u>	Users tend not to change an established behavior	<u>Time</u>
64.	 <u>Investment Loops</u>	When users invest themselves, they're more likely to come back	<u>Time</u>
65.	 <u>Loss Aversion</u>	People prefer to avoid losses more than earning equivalent gains	<u>Time</u>
66.	 <u>Commitment & Consistency</u>	Users tend to be consistent with their previous actions	<u>Time</u>
67.	 <u>Sunk Cost Effect</u>	Users are reluctant to pull out of something they're invested in.	<u>Time</u>
68.	 <u>Decision Fatigue</u>	Making a lot of decisions lowers users' ability to make rational ones	<u>Time</u>
69.	 <u>Reactance</u>	Users are less likely to adopt a behavior when they feel forced	<u>Time</u>
70.	 <u>Observer-Expectancy Effect</u>	When researchers' biases influence the participants of an experiment	<u>Time</u>

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71.	 <u>Weber's Law</u>	Users adapt better to small incremental changes	<u>Time</u>
72.	 <u>Law of the Instrument</u>	If all you have is a hammer, everything looks like a nail	<u>Time</u>
73.	 <u>Temptation Bundling</u>	Hard tasks are less scary when coupled with something users desire	<u>Time</u>
74.	 <u>Parkinson's Law</u>	The time required to complete a task will take as much time as allowed	<u>Time</u>
75.	 <u>Dunning-Kruger Effect</u>	People tend to overestimate their skills when they don't know much	<u>Time</u>
76.	 <u>Affect Heuristic</u>	People's current emotions cloud and influence their judgment	<u>Time</u>
77.	 <u>Hyperbolic Discounting</u>	People tend to prioritize immediate benefits over bigger future gains	<u>Time</u>
78.	 <u>Cashless Effect</u>	People spend more when they can't actually see the money	<u>Time</u>
79.	 <u>Chronoception</u>	People's perception of time is subjective	<u>Time</u>
80.	 <u>Self-serving bias</u>	People take credits for positive events and blame others if negative	<u>Time</u>
81.	 <u>Pareto Principle</u>	Roughly 80% of the effects come from 20% of the causes	<u>Time</u>
82.	 <u>Discoverability</u>	The ease with which users can discover your features	<u>Time</u>
83.	 <u>Backfire Effect</u>	When people's convictions are challenged, their beliefs get stronger	<u>Time</u>
84.	 <u>False Consensus Effect</u>	People overestimate how much other people agree with them	<u>Time</u>
85.	 <u>Bandwagon Effect</u>	Users tend to adopt beliefs in proportion of others who have already done so	<u>Time</u>
86.	 <u>Barnum-Forer Effect</u>	When you believe generic personality descriptions apply specifically to you.	<u>Time</u>
87.	 <u>Second-Order Effect</u>	The consequences of the consequences of actions	<u>Time</u>
88.	 <u>IKEA Effect</u>	When user partially create something, they value it way more	<u>Time</u>
89.	 <u>Planning Fallacy</u>	People tend to underestimate how much time a task will take	<u>Time</u>
90.	 <u>Provide Exit Points</u>	Invite users to leave your app at the right moment	<u>Memory</u>
91.	 <u>Peak-End Rule</u>	People judge an experience by its peak and how it ends.	<u>Memory</u>
92.	 <u>Sensory Appeal</u>	Users engage more with things appealing to multiple senses	<u>Memory</u>
93.	 <u>Zeigarnik Effect</u>	People remember incomplete tasks better than completed ones	<u>Memory</u>
94.	 <u>Endowment Effect</u>	Users value something more if they feel it's theirs	<u>Memory</u>
95.	 <u>Chunking</u>	People remember grouped information better	<u>Memory</u>

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96.	 <u>Picture Superiority Effect</u>	People remember pictures better than words	<u>Memory</u>
97.	 <u>Method of Loci</u>	People remember things more when they're associated with a location	<u>Memory</u>
98.	 <u>Shaping</u>	Incrementally reinforcing actions to get closer to a target behavior	<u>Memory</u>
99.	 <u>Delighters</u>	People remember more unexpected and playful pleasures	<u>Memory</u>
100.	 <u>Internal Trigger</u>	When users are prompted to take action based on a memory	<u>Memory</u>
101.	 <u>Recognition Over Recall</u>	It's easier to recognize things than recall them from memory	<u>Memory</u>
102.	 <u>Storytelling Effect</u>	People remember stories better than facts alone	<u>Memory</u>
103.	 <u>Negativity Bias</u>	Users recall negative events more than positive ones	<u>Memory</u>
104.	 <u>Availability Heuristic</u>	Users favor recent and available information over past information	<u>Memory</u>
105.	 <u>Spacing Effect</u>	People learn more effectively when study sessions are spaced out	<u>Memory</u>
106.	 <u>Serial Position Effect</u>	It's easier for users to recall the first and last items of a list	<u>Memory</u>



Don't miss the new ones!

We update the list every few weeks here:

<https://growth.design/psychology>.

Don't hesitate to share the link with your friends & colleagues who might enjoy it.

—Dan Benoni & Louis-Xavier Lavallée